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For the President
31 August 2026



Iran Strikes US Bases in Jordan and the UAE After US Hits Hormuz Minelayers

We assess that the tenuous US-Iran ceasefire in place since late July has broken down, at least temporarily, after the first direct exchange of fire in a month. On 30 August US Central Command struck two Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) launchers on Larak Island, in the Strait of Hormuz, describing the action as a "limited, precise" strike against minelaying forces observed preparing to seed the waterway with sea mines. Early on 31 August Iran retaliated, firing ballistic missiles at two bases hosting US personnel in Jordan and launching explosive drones at Al Minhad Air Base in the United Arab Emirates. We judge the risk of further escalation to be elevated but assess neither side currently seeks a wider war.

- Jordan's armed forces said they intercepted eight ballistic missiles that entered Jordanian airspace; Iran said the US strike on Larak killed two and wounded two more. We have no confirmed reports of US casualties from the retaliatory salvos as of this writing.
 - The IRGC publicly vowed to "punish those responsible" and warned of economic and military consequences, framing the exchange as a response to a violation of Iranian territory rather than an opening move.
 - By attacking targets in Jordan and the UAE — not US forces afloat — Tehran signaled resolve while retaining calibration, consistent with its pattern of telegraphed, largely interceptable strikes designed to satisfy domestic audiences without inviting a decapitating US response.
 - For Washington, the central question is whether the July understanding can be restored or whether minelaying attempts will now recur, forcing repeated US strikes to keep Hormuz open. We expect a further round of US messaging — public and via intermediaries — aimed at re-freezing the confrontation.
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The exchange reverberated in energy markets. Brent for November rose back above \$90 a barrel and WTI traded near \$86 as traders re-priced the risk to Gulf flows, though the move was contained: Persian Gulf exports have recovered to roughly 15-16 million barrels per day, below pre-conflict levels but far above the spring lows. We assess that a sustained closure of Hormuz remains unlikely absent a decision by Tehran to accept the economic self-harm it would entail, but even intermittent minelaying keeps a war-risk premium in the price.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CENTCOM, CIA, DIA, NSA, NGA, and open sources.

For the President
31 August 2026



SCO Summit Opens in Bishkek as Putin, Xi, and Modi Convene

We assess that the two-day Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit that opened in Bishkek on 31 August is more valuable to its principals as political theater than as a decision-making body, but that the optics themselves carry weight for US interests. Chinese President Xi Jinping, Russian President Vladimir Putin, and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi are sharing the stage alongside Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, projecting a Eurasian bloc explicitly framed as an alternative to the US-led order.

- In a Putin-Xi bilateral — their second in-person meeting of the year — the two leaders discussed the long-stalled Power of Siberia 2 gas pipeline, a project that would deepen Russia's energy dependence on China. We judge that any concrete advance would signal Beijing's growing leverage over a war-strained Moscow.
- Modi's sideline meeting with Putin, with oil, fertilizer, and the S-400 on the agenda, underscores New Delhi's continued hedging. Coming amid US-India trade friction, the warmth on display is partly a message to Washington about the costs of pressure.
- The summit is expected to produce a Bishkek Declaration on regional security, counterterrorism, and connectivity. We assess the document will be long on principles and short on binding commitments, consistent with the SCO's consensus-bound, lowest-common-denominator record.

For Washington, the meeting is less about what the SCO decides than about the alignment it advertises. We expect no breakthrough among members whose interests — especially India's and China's — diverge sharply, but the recurring image of the three leaders together is itself a strategic signal the US should weigh.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, INR, and open sources.

For the President
31 August 2026



Russia's Deadliest Strike of the Year Kills 38 Near Kyiv

We assess that Russia's intensified long-range air campaign against Ukraine is inflicting mounting civilian costs even as the front lines move little. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on 30 August that the death toll from a Friday-night strike on a warehouse in the village of Myla, west of Kyiv, had risen to 38 — the war's deadliest single attack this year — with four still missing and about 20 injured. Ukrainian officials said the site stored ammunition, and the strike touched off secondary explosions that engulfed nearby homes.

- The strike was the second on a munitions depot near Kyiv within two months, and Ukrainian officials voiced anger that arms were still being stored close to residential areas — a vulnerability we assess Russia is deliberately exploiting.
- Moscow has sharply escalated its use of drones and guided bombs in recent weeks, subjecting the capital to repeated overnight barrages. We judge the campaign is intended to exhaust Ukrainian air defenses and erode civilian morale ahead of any negotiation.
- Russian officials have said they are open to "new ideas" on ending the war, but only on terms matching Putin's stated goals. We assess the diplomatic signaling is tactical and that Moscow currently sees more advantage in military pressure than in a settlement.

For Washington and NATO, the pattern reinforces Kyiv's acute and continuing need for air-defense interceptors. We expect Ukrainian appeals for additional Patriot capacity to intensify; Kyiv has floated trading domestically produced drone technology to the US in exchange for interceptors.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from DIA, NGA, INR, and open sources.

For the President
31 August 2026



Niger Junta Suppresses Mutiny With Russian Africa Corps Help

We assess that the military government of General Abdourahamane Tiani has survived the most serious internal challenge since it seized power in July 2023, but that the mutiny exposes real fissures within Niger's security forces. Hundreds of disaffected soldiers attacked the presidency, state broadcaster, and Base 101 near Niamey's international airport in overnight fighting from 29 to 30 August; by 31 August the junta — backed by fighters from Russia's Africa Corps — said it had retaken the seized sites, and life in the capital had largely returned to normal.

- Security sources link the unrest to frustration over worsening insecurity and heavy troop losses to jihadist groups in frontline areas such as Ouallam, Tera, and Dosso. We judge morale in the ranks to be a persistent vulnerability for the junta.
- The episode is a live test of Moscow's expanding Sahel footprint: Base 101 hosts Africa Corps personnel and command elements of the Alliance of Sahel States, the Niger-Burkina Faso-Mali bloc that broke from ECOWAS.
- Niger is a major uranium producer, and continued instability bears on global supply and on the residual Western presence the junta has steadily curtailed since 2023.

For Washington, the mutiny underscores how thoroughly Russia has supplanted Western security partners in the central Sahel. We assess Tiani will now move to purge suspected plotters, and that the reliance on Russian paramilitaries to hold power will deepen — narrowing US and French options in the region further.

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For the President
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Israel and Greece Sign Record Air-Defense Pact as Gaza Truce Frays

We assess that the roughly \$3.5 billion "Achilles Shield" air-defense agreement signed by Israel and Greece on 31 August — the largest defense-export deal in Israel's history — marks a durable deepening of an eastern-Mediterranean alignment aimed principally at Turkey and, secondarily, Iran. Negotiated over three years, the deal will equip Greece with a multi-layered system built around Rafael's David's Sling and SPYDER and Israel Aerospace Industries' Barak MX, tied together by a national command-and-control center incorporating AI.

- The pact binds a NATO member more tightly to Israel's defense-industrial base at a moment of strained Greek-Turkish relations, and roughly €700 million is expected to flow to Greek subcontractors — an economic sweetener that anchors the partnership.
- For Washington, the deal advances interoperability among partners but also complicates intra-NATO dynamics with Turkey, whose reaction we will be watching.

On Gaza, the US-brokered ceasefire in place since October is fraying. Israeli strikes killed at least two people in Gaza City on 31 August in what Palestinian sources called the latest violation, and mediators have warned that the collapse of the truce process — after Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu rejected the administration's 15-point plan — would be a "point of no return." We assess the ceasefire is eroding at the margins rather than collapsing outright, but the trend line is negative.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from INR, DIA, NGA, and open sources.

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Glacial Outburst Flood Devastates the Nepal-China Border

We assess that the catastrophic flooding along the Nepal-China (Tibet) frontier is among the deadliest natural disasters in the Himalaya in years and is likely to strain Kathmandu's response capacity for weeks. Authorities attribute the disaster to a portion of a glacier near the Langtang Lirung peak breaking away and plunging into the river below, triggering an avalanche and a downstream surge of water, ice, and rock. As of 30 August, Nepali officials reported more than 700 dead, Chinese authorities at least 16, and roughly 3,000 people missing.

- More than 900 workers at hydropower projects are among the missing; crews are racing to reach any survivors trapped inside inundated tunnels, an effort the government has called its highest priority.
- Officials have buried nearly 200 unidentified bodies as morgue capacity is overwhelmed — an indicator of the scale and of the public-health challenge now emerging.

We judge the event will intensify scrutiny of hydropower construction in glacial-hazard zones and of glacial-lake-outburst risk across the high Himalaya, a concern with direct bearing on Chinese, Indian, and Nepali infrastructure. For the US, the immediate relevance is humanitarian; the longer-term signal is the compounding instability of high-altitude water systems on which South Asia depends.

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Notes

Korean Peninsula. Diplomatic signaling between Washington and Pyongyang remains at cross-purposes. President Trump has said he wants to revive talks and expects to meet Kim Jong Un this year, but Pyongyang answered a US drawdown of joint exercises with a barrage of short-range missile launches, and Kim Yo Jong publicly denied any recent leader-level communication. We assess no near-term breakthrough is likely; Pyongyang is raising its price.

- **Israel-Spain.** Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez accused Israel and Russia of amplifying disinformation around the Ceuta migrant crisis, the latest friction in a badly deteriorated Madrid-Jerusalem relationship — a reminder of the widening European political rift with Israel over Gaza.
- **Gaza home front.** Israeli protesters again gathered outside Netanyahu's residence on 31 August, marking two years since six hostages' bodies were recovered from a Gaza tunnel and renewing demands for a state commission of inquiry the government has refused. Domestic pressure on Netanyahu over the hostage file is not abating.
- **Energy watch.** Despite the Hormuz exchange, analysts increasingly read the US-Iran standoff as an economic and sanctions confrontation rather than an imminent threat to physical oil supply — a judgment that has capped price spikes but would reverse quickly on any successful mining of the strait.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, INR, Treasury OIA, and open sources.